

# IRISA LEE

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## EDUCATION

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**PhD in Economics**, UNC Chapel Hill 2020 - Present  
Expected graduation date: May 2026

**B.A. in Economics**, Mount Holyoke College 2014 - 2018  
*Magna cum laude*, minor in Mathematics

## RESEARCH INTERESTS

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Macroeconomics, Money and Banking, Corporate Finance

## WORKING PAPERS

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- "Central Bank Digital Currency, Bank Capital, and Risk". (*Job Market Paper*)

This paper studies the effect of introducing interest-bearing central bank digital currency (CBDC) on bank capital structure and the quality of bank lending. Banks have access to productive investment projects that can be funded either by equity capital or bank deposits and require bank effort. Deposits are necessary as a medium of exchange and therefore can have a liquidity premium that lowers the interest rates that banks pay on them, but this also introduces a moral hazard problem with bank effort. A CBDC can compete with bank deposits and raise deposit interest rates, which raises efficiency in exchange for depositors. However, the effect on bank lending depends on their ability to raise capital. If banks have high net worth and have no difficulty switching to capital funding, then higher deposit rates lead to higher bank effort. If banks are restricted by their net worth, then this can lead to either less effort or less lending. Thus an interest-bearing CBDC can lead to welfare losses if banks face equity constraints.

## WORKS IN PROGRESS

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- "Risky Entrepreneurship and Taxation".
- "Digital Currency and Capital".

## RELEVANT EXPERIENCE

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**Summer Research Fellow** Summer 2024  
Federal Deposit Insurance Corporation, Center for Financial Research *Washington, DC*

**Senior Research Assistant** 2018 - 2020  
Federal Reserve Board, Division of Research and Statistics (Risk Analysis section) *Washington, DC*

## AWARDS/HONORS

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UNC Economics Department Fellowship 2020 - 2025  
Mary Lyon Scholar for high honors on a thesis, MHC 2018

## TEACHING EXPERIENCES

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UNC Chapel Hill:

**Instructor of Record**  
ECON 423: Financial Markets and Economic Fluctuations Fall 2024

## Selected Teaching Assistant Experience

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|-------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------|
| ECON 425: Financial Economics                         | Spring 2026                        |
| ECON 423: Financial Markets and Economic Fluctuations | Spring 2025                        |
| ECON 420: Intermediate Macroeconomics                 | Fall 2023 - Spring 2024, Fall 2025 |
| IDST 126: Values and Prices                           | Spring 2023                        |
| ECON 101: Introduction to Economics                   | Fall 2022                          |
| ECON 126: Introduction to Entrepreneurship            | Fall 2021                          |

## Other

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| R for Economists: Introductory Workshop (Instructor) | Summer 2022, Summer 2023 |
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## PRESENTATIONS

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**2024:** FDIC Internal Seminar

**2025:** WEAI Graduate Student Workshop

## TECHNICAL SKILLS

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Python, R, LaTeX, Linux, Stata

## REFERENCES

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Stanislav Rabinovich (*Advisor*)

Associate Professor of Economics at UNC Chapel Hill  
srabinov@email.unc.edu

Can Tian (*Committee member*)

Associate Professor of Economics at UNC Chapel Hill  
tiancan@email.unc.edu

Lukas Altermatt (*Committee member*)

Assistant Professor of Economics at the University of Bern  
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Christopher Roark (*Teaching*)

Associate Teaching Professor at UNC Chapel Hill  
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